

Waves in Air

Love, Conflict, and What it Means to Communicate

Overview

The player takes the role of a courier. The plot walks through a couple of different areas. Each area is inspired by a medium of communication, and they will touch on various emotions brought on by miscommunication. The courier's role is to act as a medium, resolving conflicts throughout the story by translating what one group says to another.

Overarching Problem

The courier carries letters written by a scientist, describing a massive storm caused by overuse of certain energy pylons that are pushing some energy into the atmosphere. Unless addressed, massive storms will break out, causing storm surge and rising sea levels to plunge many areas underwater and causing massive loss of life.

The courier's main goal is to deliver the letters to important figures in different areas, and relay the information that the scientist gave them. However, each area might have their own situation, culture, or method to solve problems, and the courier must overcome them to save as many lives as possible.

Opening

The game opens with the player checking their letters on the boat, and making sure that everything is in place. All of a sudden, a huge gust of wind starts blowing (hinting at the formation of a storm) and the water starts to churn even though the skies are still blue. The courier is caught in this, and though they try to escape, they are caught and tossed about until the screen cuts to black.

Area 1

General Theming

The first area will be a tutorial area, focusing on a lone radio station.

Miscommunication often leaves people feeling isolated, desperate, and alone. This will be reflected in the first area, as a simple yet strong opening to introduce the player to the core themes of miscommunication.

This will primarily be done in the following ways:

- The only interactable person on the island will be the person manning the radio tower
- A lot of the story will be told through what physical correspondence the radio operator has lying around
- Tuning the antenna to find a frequency aligns with the idea of reaching out and hoping someone else reaches out too
- The radio operator attempts to communicate with others using the letter

Plot

The courier washes up on the shore of the island. After taking a couple of moments to regain their bearings, they check on their supplies. One of the letters in their bag is addressed to this island; upon realizing this, the courier sets out to deliver the letter.

The courier explores the island, walking through thick forest until they reach a poorly-maintained radio station. The flower beds look dead, and vines cover the building. After inspecting the area briefly, the courier knocks on the door to deliver the letter. However, they only receive loud shouting in response. The radio operator does not want anyone visiting the island, as he only wants to conduct work in isolation.

To convince the operator to hear them out, the courier cleans up the exterior of the radio station. They clear up the vines and water the flower beds so that the flowers bloom. Upon knocking once more, the radio operator comes out, and reluctantly thanks the courier for the work. The operator then invites the courier inside for tea before heading back inside themselves.

Only at this point does the operator accept the letter. When they inspect it, their demeanor immediately softens. Unbeknownst to the courier, this letter had been sent from his daughter, whom he hadn't spoken to for some time. The courier interrupts the reading to mention that the ship they were sailing on had sunk and that they would need a ride to the next island.

The operator offers to use the local radio to ask nearby ferries to carry the courier, but mentions that it is broken and would need to be fixed before it can be used. The courier is told to go fetch tools to fix the frequency modulator from the bedroom. When the courier enters, they can inspect the room for photos of the operator with a similarly-aged woman, as well as a child. The photographs are kept in a secure place, so it's likely that these are people of value. Then, the courier retrieves the toolbox and brings it to the operator.

The operator accepts the tools, and then moves to fix the modulator. He gets zapped, and asks the courier to help fix it. The courier must engage in a puzzle to perform several operations on wires of different colors and incorrectly-marked color labels (e.g. blue-colored wire labeled "red"). To solve the puzzle, the courier must focus on what the operator is saying, rather than what the courier can see.

Once the modulator is fixed, the courier is told to ascend the radio tower, where they can directly adjust the position of the dish to tune it. After listening to the commands of the operator, the courier can re-tune it and successfully call a ferry.

Just before the courier leaves, the operator gives the courier a letter, addressed to the same person who sent the original letter. The operator also gives a small pouch of coins as a fee, and thanks the courier with a smile before parting ways.

Area 2

General Theming

The second area will be more complex than the first. It will be themed after modern-day Egypt, with ancient monuments alongside more contemporary city architecture. The communication device that the area will be based around is books and writing, since Egyptians had an extensive array of methods for written media.

Miscommunication can also occur on a larger scale, causing large rifts between groups of people. Misinformation, prejudice, and other forms of preexisting bias pushes people to distrust others, forming distinct groups and an “us versus them” mentality. This will be reflected in the second area by splitting society into an upper and lower class and showing how this informs their interactions.

The themes will primarily be reflected in the following ways:

- The upper class will live in more ancient Egypt
 - Temples, pyramids
 - More spread out
 - Greater emphasis on the past and tradition
- The lower class will live in more modern Egypt
 - modern buildings and tight-knit city
 - much more dirty, less reading
 - greater emphasis on change, often repeating mistakes
 - people will have more diverse opinions, but will struggle to communicate (more conflict)
- People in either area will have incorrect assumptions or stories about the other group
- The youth will be able to communicate more freely, since they haven't been educated in the prejudices yet

Plot

The courier arrives in the second area by ferry, landing in a run-down dock area. The courier, not knowing where to go, asks the ferryman where the delivery address is. Wordlessly, the ferryman

points to a tall, shining tower in the distance before returning to work. The courier can inspect the surrounding area of very busy dockhands, and then move on to the dense city.

The courier enters the dense part of the city, where illiteracy is very high. It's a very busy city; people are working and talking, but there are only a few written signs. Those in leadership positions are the few literate in the area, and the signs are for them, pointing to places of relaxation or places where workers rarely need to go. In addition, those in leadership positions seem to be better off or mistreating those who can't read. To progress through this area, the courier navigates a maze of alleyways, locked doors, and open streets, getting a full tour of the area before progressing to the next.

Before they can move on, the courier gets bumped by some raucous delinquents and drops the letter they pulled out briefly. The delinquents pick up the letter, and amused by the courier's attempts to get it back, they take the letter and run away with it. To retrieve it, the courier must follow them stealthily and steal it back. When sneaking around, the courier notices how the older generations teach their views of the rich area. They characterize them as rich, careless, abusive, and power-abusing. They teach that the children are just as rotten, and should be avoided at all cost. Crucially, the courier notices that the delinquents don't pay the elders as much mind. The courier retrieves the letter (which was abandoned, since the delinquents have no use for written language) before moving on.

The richer part of the city is much different compared to the poorer area. Here, there are written signs everywhere, making traversal much easier. In addition, the buildings look much older, almost like temples or other ancient buildings. There are also far fewer people; the only people on the streets seem to be people taking languid walks or chatting during lunch. There is a group of teenagers reading and laughing. They seem to be disturbing the passerby, but they don't seem to care. The courier continues their trek to the large tower by traveling through this area. On their way, they pass by a huge library. Inside, there are millions of books covering all of the walls, and they're incredibly well kept. However, there's nobody inside, and nobody seems to care about reading books. The courier is still barred entry, though, as they are an outsider and not obviously literate (rich).

When the courier reaches the huge tower, the courier is stopped by a guard. The courier shows the letter to the guard, and they are let through. After ascending a large flight of stairs, the courier arrives at the leader's tower. Up here, there are more untouched books, as well as an opulent desk with an idle leader. The leader grandly welcomes the courier, and asks what they need. The courier delivers the letter, and they read it aloud, boastfully.

The leader finishes reading, and heartily laughs. They say that the storm is nothing to be concerned about; the scientists have already done extensive reading on storms in the past, and have arranged the city in such a way that the rich area will be left untouched. When asked about

the poorer area, the leader seems unconcerned, and says that there is an emergency route that is probably fine. The leader refuses to spread the message, and dismisses the courier.

The courier visits the emergency route to move to the next area, but it's broken down and unusable. The courier returns to the poor area to alert them, but notices that the teenagers from the poor area and the teenagers from the rich area are playing together by the wall that separates the areas. Seeing this as an opportunity, the courier approaches them, and lets them know of the issue. They are immediately alarmed, but confer between themselves. They agree that their elders will never work together, and if they want to live, they have to do the work themselves. Together, they concoct a plan.

The courier goes with the rich teenagers to distract the guards of the library. Together, they steal old archived materials on the construction of the emergency route. Then, the courier sneaks the teenagers from the poorer area (who are better with working with their hands) to the emergency route. In the end, the teenagers from the rich area cooperate with the teenagers from the poor area to fix the route, and the courier takes the way out while the teenagers move to save as many lives as they can.

Area 3

General Theming

The third area will be more simple than the previous at first glance, but its main challenge comes from how difficult the communication barriers may be. The communication device that the area will be themed around is semaphore, non-verbal communication in multiple forms, such as fires or flags. The region will be stylized around Greece due to Grecian society being the first to have notable examples of semaphore.

Communication is a very personal thing. Each person begins with some internalization of a language, then uses that understanding to express ideas to another. The listener then takes what is expressed and translates it with their own dictionary. In this way, each person speaks their own language. In some communities, although there is some shared understanding between community members, there are still gaps between small subgroups, and even your neighbors can feel like strangers. I hope to reflect this idea of personal communication and separation within a community through the use of semaphore.

The area will be a mountain range, with people spread out across valleys and peaks in small pocket communities. The climate will be snowy, so people are often clustered around fires. Traversing to other groups is somewhat arduous in the snow, so to communicate outside of their own families/groups, people will primarily use semaphore. However, different families may use different forms of semaphore, such as lights, smoke, fire, or flags.

Plot

The courier arrives through the emergency route to the foot of a mountain range. The way ahead is blocked by a massive stone gate; the courier will need to find another way around. They also have a letter to deliver to the mountain gatekeepers, so they set foot into the mountains.

The snowfall is incredibly heavy and going is very slow. Eventually, the courier happens upon a small house near the top of one of the peaks. When they knock, they can hear sounds of people removing reinforcements and planks before a short figure opens the door and ushers the courier in, quickly closing the door behind them.

The courier is greeted by a small family. They describe themselves as guides, but they've been forced to winterize due to the unnaturally harsh storm. The courier describes the incoming storm that's coming from the letter, and the family grows worried. The family offers to tell the courier how to reach the gatekeepers, but only on the condition that they fetch medicine from the neighboring family. The courier agrees, and makes to set off before the family mentions that they have a semaphore system.

The courier is taught some pieces of a flag code, and waves to the neighboring family. They raise flags in response, and then extend a rope bridge connecting the two houses. The courier goes over, retrieves medicine, and then brings it back to the first family. The first family thanks the courier, and then hands the courier a compass. They tell the courier some directions to reach the gatekeeper, and bid farewell.

When the courier travels back along the bridge, they reach the neighboring family, and a similar situation occurs. The family is told of the emergency, wants to give medicine to and alert the family a couple of houses over, and has a separate semaphore system that the courier must learn if they want to communicate and build a path over.

This pattern is repeated a couple of times in a complex maze/puzzle system. Throughout the puzzle, the courier learns of different relationships between different families, secret thoughts that each of them have, and more. The courier takes time to correct bad impressions people might've given others, bring supplies to people who need it, and raise awareness of the incoming storm.

In the end, the courier is eventually able to reach the gatekeepers. The courier delivers the letters, and they wordlessly read the letters before opening the stone gates, and allowing the courier to take a shortcut back down the mountain and to the other side.

Area 4

General Theming

The fourth area's main challenges will be in determining what is true and what is false and figuring out how to get the attention of others. The communication device that the area will be themed around is social media, focusing mainly on how social media can both isolate and connect people through miscommunication and community. The area will be stylistically themed after Dubai with elements of cyberpunk and sci-fi design, as these thematically connect to social media and the progression of technology at the expense of people.

Communication has always been inefficient; there are challenges in meeting with people to converse, as well as challenges in reading and writing information to others. With the advent of social media, however, reaching and communicating with others has been made trivially easy. Social media has also had other consequences, though. Miscommunication has been empowered to reach millions of people almost instantly, and many people have become more reliant on short-term enjoyment and stimulus. Society has changed to be much faster-paced, shown through the rise of short-form content and rapid spread of misinformation through social media.

The area will be a dense city, painted in dark blue and gray save for neon signs of every color of the rainbow. The streets are empty, and the few people that do walk around wear masquerade and theatre masks that cover their face. However, there is also a virtual world that most people are in. Here, people float around as ghosts, gravitating around whatever is entertaining or engaging, whether it is misinformation, people getting hurt, or other crises in the world. The courier will need to balance navigation in the real world and the digital world to progress through the area.

Plot

The courier arrives in the fourth area after taking the shortcut through the mountains from area three. They notice a letter addressed to them. Upon opening, the courier receives some explanation.

The storm is a natural weather phenomenon, formed of concentrated energy that accumulates in the atmosphere over time. The energy accumulates very slowly and usually the storms that form don't pose much of a threat, and dissipate periodically in a safe way. However, the overuse of certain energy generation is inefficient and puts excess energy into the air, disrupting the balance and causing this storm to pose a great deal of harm. In addition, if the storm passes over a generator on land, it will break the generator and take the energy, causing the storm to grow greatly and spread to cause massive catastrophe across the continent.

There is an energy director who is friends with the sender of the letter. They've been developing solutions in collaboration with their friend, and this letter is meant to urge them to switch to a prototype energy solution that should produce energy in a manner that can't worsen the storm.

After reviewing the contents of the letter, the courier sets off into the city to find the person to deliver the letter to.

The city is shining with billboards and lights, and it is a very beautiful city. However, there aren't any people around; the streets are barren and the city is silent. The courier heads to the address provided in the letter, and follows it to the basement of an office building.

The energy director greets the courier, and accepts the letter. As she reads, she gets visibly worried. She mentions that public reception of the alternate energy source is... poor. She says that, until her superiors are convinced that it is safe, she cannot implement the solution. She points out that her superiors spend more time online than at work, though. Fixing public perception online could garner support faster. The energy director gives the courier directions to pick up a media mask, where they can enter the social network to do their work.

The courier stops by the media mask store, a brightly lit building with a line stretching around the corner. When the courier stops by the window to make sure that this is the correct building, someone by the door laughs at the courier's appearance, calls them a cosplayer, and invites them to take a photo. When the courier reluctantly agrees and approaches, the door swings open and the bouncer allows the next group in. The courier is pulled along, skipping the line. The courier can swipe a card they got from the energy director to get the media mask, a VR headset stylized like a masquerade mask.

When the courier puts on the mask, they are taken to a virtual world where people are rendered in translucent, colorful, spirit-like apparitions floating between different interesting things. The courier notices that there are the most people around sensational things, especially things that aren't true. When the courier asks around about the energy alternative, people react negatively, bringing to the forefront many different "posts" about the negative effects of the alternative. However, these are false information, as they contain stories from past areas that aren't true, unreliable sources, etc.

The courier must investigate each of these posts and prove them in real life by going to some place to meet experts, share their own experiences in different locations, or show that some information is told by scared people to scared people as rumors.

Along the way, the courier can meet people who share the same view, and they help the courier spread the message about the dangers of the current energy source.

In the end, the courier is able to prove that the new energy source is better. Once this is accomplished, the courier returns to the energy director, who successfully transfers the city over to the new solution.

It starts to rain in the city; the storm is nearly here. The courier sets off in a hurry to meet back with the sender.

Area 5

General Theming

The fifth area will be free of challenges and puzzles, instead dedicated to resolving the story. It will be themed after an observatory, rather than a real-world region. The “communication” device that the area will be inspired by is the telescope.

Miscommunication can leave people isolated and distanced. After people are estranged and struggle to reconnect, an important factor to reconnecting is caring about the other person. This is represented in the following ways:

- The astronomer can't reach out to those they want to protect, except through the letters they give the courier
- Although they're separated from others, they still care for them from afar
- The astronomer has grown apart from their father (the radio operator) but they still appreciate hearing from them, despite how much each of them has grown separately

Plot

The courier arrives in the final area, just a short distance from the previous area. It is an observatory placed on a small island, far away from the light pollution of the city. The courier knocks, and someone calls from within to come in.

The courier comes in, and is greeted by a dark observatory. Only one desk with a small lamp is lit, and behind it sits a woman who is writing something down. She looks up and greets the courier, asking if all of the letters were delivered. The courier affirms, and she smiles.

She digs through the desk and pulls out a small pouch of coins, offering it to him to complete their transaction.

At this point, the courier can ask some questions, such as:

- How could they predict such a horrible storm?
 - The observatory comes with weather equipment. The astronomer already knows how to use weather equipment from father, and uses it to get clear readings. When they noticed things were off, they contacted friends and discovered a storm.
- Why did you only pay half?
 - Wanted to ensure delivery, whatever
- etc.

Before the courier departs, they remember that they have a letter to deliver. They pull out the letter from the radio operator, and hand it to the astronomer. She smiles, and says it's from her father. She hadn't heard from him since her mother had passed and she ran away from the boarding school her father had sent her to.

She asks the courier to wait for a moment, writes a letter, and gives it to the courier. The courier waits expectantly, but she sheepishly asks the courier to request payment from the father. The courier sighs, and sets off to deliver the letter.

Conclusion

This is where the game will end. What happens next is up to interpretation.